

CHAPTER 4

GETTING BITTER

'Get up, you bastard!'

A new team that came after the DIG's lightning visit was more brutal. One of them shouted, 'Get up, you bastard! You don't deserve to sit anymore.' I stood up. I'd had no food all day. I had kept asking for water, which they gave. Now they stopped giving me water. They threatened to take me to a torture cell somewhere in Pathankot or Kashmir, where they said I could be killed and my body thrown away, without anyone asking any questions. 'We would say that you escaped from our custody,' one of them said.

I visualized being killed and my body being thrown into snow-covered wilderness. And then, images of my father crossed my mind. I remembered his advice. If you face a crisis, he had told me as a child, be prepared for the worst. That night's questioning by teams that came in shifts, not allowing me to sit or sleep for more than thirty hours, drained me. At one point, I felt a sense of coldness seeping into my body from the cement floor.

I felt dizzy, and thought it must be approaching death. It was easy to yield to it, end it all. For a moment I thought I should let myself go. But I fought back. I summoned that last warmth leaving my body, took deep breaths and stood my ground.

I spoke.

'You guys are committing a big crime, and you will be punished for this.'